DBL Data Converter

User Guide

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1 Introduction

1.1 Purpose

The DBL Data Converter reads the data files of a DBL accounting system and writes their contents to spreadsheet files that open in Microsoft Excel, and to a single SQLite database. It allows the accounting records to be read, searched and retained after the original system has been retired, and provides a starting point for transferring them to another system.

1.2 Scope

The converter reads relative data files (extension .DDF) and sequential files unloaded from ISAM files (extension .SEQ). It interprets each file using the record layouts of the accounting system, which are built into the program; 339 layouts are included.

The converter does not read ISAM files (.ISM, .IS1) directly; these must first be unloaded as described in section 4.3. It opens all source files read-only and does not modify them.

1.3 Conventions

Names of buttons, menus and fields in the program window are shown in **bold**. File and folder names are shown as they appear on screen, for example CONVERSION REPORT.txt.

2 System Requirements

Item	Requirement
Operating system	Windows 10 or Windows 11, 64-bit. Earlier versions of Windows, including Windows XP and Windows 7, are not supported.
Additional software	None. Microsoft Excel, or another spreadsheet program, is needed to view the output.
Disk space	20 MB for the program, and free space of at least twice the size of the source data folder.
User account	A standard user account. Administrator rights are not required.
Network	Not required. The program does not connect to the internet or to any other computer.

3 Installation

3.1 Installing the program

The program is supplied as a single file, **DBL Data Converter.exe**. No installer is required. Copy the file to a convenient location on the computer, such as the Desktop or a folder in Documents, and start it by double-clicking it.

3.2 First start

On the first start, Windows may display the message **Windows protected your PC**. This message appears for programs that have not been registered with Microsoft. To continue, select **More info** and then **Run anyway**. The message does not appear on later starts.

3.3 Removing the program

Delete the file DBL Data Converter.exe. The program makes no other changes to the computer.

4 Preparing the Data

4.1 Copying the data folder

The converter must always be used on a copy of the data, never on the folder used by the accounting system. Copy the complete data folder from the computer that runs the accounting system to the computer on which the converter will be used, by means of a USB drive or a shared network folder.

> **Important:** Make the copy while the accounting system is not in use, so that no file is being changed during copying. Keep the original folder unchanged until the converted data has been verified as described in section 7.

4.2 Files the converter reads

Extension	Treatment
.DDF	Relative data files. Converted directly. Record 1 is the file's control record (see section 6.3).
.SEQ	Sequential files unloaded from ISAM files (see section 4.3). Converted directly; every record is data.
.ISM, .IS1	ISAM files. Not read; listed in the conversion report until an unloaded .SEQ file is supplied.
Other	Ignored.

4.3 Unloading ISAM files

ISAM files store records in an indexed format that the converter cannot read directly. Each ISAM file must be unloaded to a sequential file with the **ISLOAD** utility of the accounting system, on the computer that runs it. Refer to the documentation of the accounting system for the operation of ISLOAD.

Give each unloaded file the same name as the ISAM file, with the extension .SEQ. For example, AR01ARCU.ISM is unloaded to AR01ARCU.SEQ. Place the .SEQ files in the copied data folder before running the conversion.

5 Converting the Data

5.1 The program window

Control	Function
Source data folder	The folder that contains the copied data files. The number of data files found is shown beneath it.
Output folder	The folder in which the results are saved. A folder name is proposed automatically next to the source folder.
Convert	Starts the conversion.
View Report	Opens the conversion report once a conversion has finished.
Open Output Folder	Opens the output folder in File Explorer.
Activity	Lists each file as it is converted.
Help menu	Opens this guide and shows the program version.

5.2 Procedure

1. Start **DBL Data Converter**.
2. Next to **Source data folder**, select **Browse…** and choose the copied data folder. Check that the number of data files shown beneath the field is as expected.
3. Check the **Output folder**. To save the results elsewhere, select **Browse…** and choose another folder. The output folder must not be inside the source data folder.
4. Select **Convert**. Progress is shown in the progress bar and in the **Activity** list.
5. When the conversion is complete, a summary is displayed. Select **Yes** to open the conversion report.
6. Read the conversion report and carry out the checks in section 7.

> **Note:** If the output folder already contains the results of an earlier conversion, the program asks for confirmation before replacing them. Converting the same data again produces the same results.

6 Output

6.1 Contents of the output folder

Item	Contents
CONVERSION REPORT.txt	A record of the conversion: the files converted, the number of records in each, any files not converted and the reason, and the checks required.

Item	Contents
Spreadsheets (CSV)	A folder containing one spreadsheet file (.csv) for each converted data file, named after the data file. Each row is one record; the first column, _record, is the record's position in the original file.
_conversion_errors.csv	In the Spreadsheets (CSV) folder. Lists any field that could not be read, with its original contents. Such fields are left blank in the spreadsheets.
converted.sqlite	A single SQLite database containing every converted table, for use when transferring the data to another system.

6.2 Opening the spreadsheets in Excel

Double-click a .csv file to open it in Excel. On opening, Excel reformats certain values for display: account and reference numbers may lose leading zeros (00123 is shown as 123), and long numbers may be shown in scientific notation (1.23E+11). The values stored in the .csv file are unaffected.

To keep such values exactly as stored, open Excel first, select **Data**, then **From Text/CSV**, choose the file, select **Transform Data**, and set the type of the affected columns to **Text**.

> **Important:** Do not save changes over the original .csv files. To keep an edited copy, use **Save As** and choose the Excel Workbook (.xlsx) format.

6.3 Control records

The first record of each relative data file (.DDF) is a control record used internally by the accounting system, for example to hold the number of records in use. It is not included in the spreadsheets. It is kept unchanged in the _control_records table of converted.sqlite.

6.4 Amounts and decimal places

Amounts are stored exactly as recorded, with the decimal point placed according to the record layout (for example 1234.56). No rounding takes place.

7 Verifying the Results

Before the converted data is relied upon, it must be compared with reports printed from the accounting system. The following checks are recommended:

- The number of customers, vendors and employees matches the corresponding listing reports.
- The total of open receivables and payables matches the aged trial balance reports.
- The general ledger account balances match the trial balance for the same period.
- A sample of individual records, such as several customers and invoices chosen at random, matches the printed detail in every field.

Section 2 of the conversion report lists further checks for the particular conversion, including any file marked **[CHECK LAYOUT]**. Keep the conversion report with the converted data as a record of the conversion.

8 Troubleshooting

Message or condition	Cause	Action
Windows protected your PC	The program is not registered with Microsoft.	Select More info, then Run anyway (section 3.2).
No data files (.DDF or .SEQ) were found	The selected folder is not the data folder.	Select the folder that contains the data files.
A file is listed under Files not converted: no matching record layout	The file name does not identify its record layout.	Specify the layout in layouts.csv (Appendix A).
A file is listed under Files not converted: the file is empty	The file contains no data.	No action required.
A file is marked [CHECK LAYOUT]	More than one record layout matched the file equally well.	Compare the file's spreadsheet with a printed report. If the fields do not match, specify the correct layout (Appendix A).
Fields that could not be read is above zero	Some fields contain values that do not match the record layout.	Review _conversion_errors.csv and compare the affected records with printed reports.
ISAM files are listed in section 5 of the report	ISAM files cannot be read directly.	Unload them as described in section 4.3 and convert again.
The output folder already contains files	An earlier conversion was saved to the same folder.	Confirm to replace the earlier results, or choose another output folder.

9 Data Protection

The data files contain personal information about customers and employees, which may include names, addresses, pay records and tax identification numbers. The converted output contains the same information and must be protected in the same way as the original data.

- The converter processes all data on the local computer. It does not transmit data over a network or to any third party.
- Store the copied data and the output folder in a location accessible only to authorised persons.
- Delete working copies, including copies on USB drives, when they are no longer required.

- Do not send the data or the output by email. The conversion report contains file names and counts only, and may be shared for support purposes.

Appendix A: Specifying a Record Layout

The converter identifies the record layout of each file from the file name. A file name such as AR01SALC.DDF consists of a module code (AR), a company number (01) and a file code (SALC). Where the file code does not identify a layout, the file is not converted, and the conversion report lists the layouts whose record length fits the file.

To specify the layout for such a file:

1. Open Notepad.
2. Enter one line for each file, in the form FILE,LAYOUT. The layout is entered exactly as listed in the conversion report. For example:

   ```
   file,layout
   GL01MAST.DDF,GLAMS.FD:GLAMS
   ```

3. Save the file in the source data folder with the name layouts.csv. In the Save As dialog, set **Save as type** to **All files**.
4. Run the conversion again.

A layout given in layouts.csv takes precedence over the automatic selection. If the layout's record length does not fit the file, the file is not converted and the report states the reason. Lines beginning with # are ignored.